

Paper

Helping people make their **MARK**

When it first appeared around 2,000 years ago, paper made writing and reading easier than ever before.

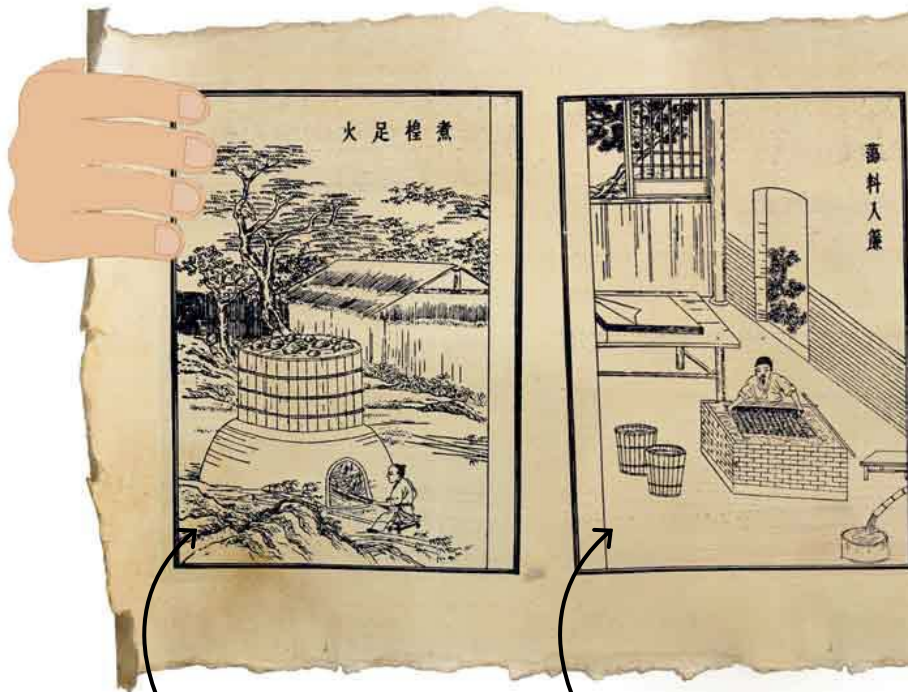
Chinese paper

Before paper was invented, people struggled with heavy books made of bamboo or spent fortunes on **expensive silk**. Legend has it that Chinese politician Ts'ai Lun revealed his papermaking technique to the **EMPEROR** in 105 CE, but even older paper, from around 100 BCE, has been discovered. **It took hundreds of years** for the secrets of papermaking to spread to other parts of Asia and North Africa, and more than 1,000 years for it to reach Europe.



The write stuff

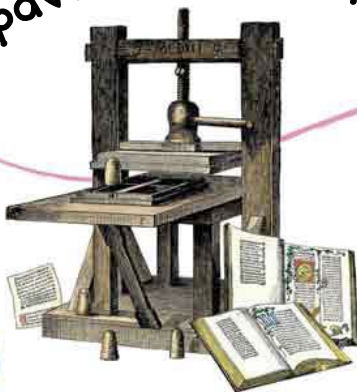
The very **FIRST WRITTEN WORDS** were scratched onto clay slabs in ancient Mesopotamia (modern-day Iraq) more than **5,000 years ago**. Later, people wrote on silk, bone, and bamboo in China, animal skin in Europe, and papyrus in Egypt. The Aztecs and Mayans in South and Central America wrote on a type of paper made from the **bark of the amate tree**.



Plant fibers are cooked with lye (a cleaning agent) before being rinsed and beaten into a pulp.

The pulp is spread over a wooden screen, resembling a flat, square sieve.

It paved the way for...



Invented around 1450 in Germany, the **PRINTING PRESS** eventually made books available to **EVERYONE**.



The first **PAPER MONEY** was used in China in the **800s**, but didn't reach Europe until the 1600s.